



ALMA MATER STUDIORUM
UNIVERSITÀ DI BOLOGNA

Department of Physics and Astronomy "A. Righi"

Theoretical Physics

Quantum Field Theory II

Lectures held by
Prof. Tiziano Peraro

Notes by
Gioele Mancino

Academic Year 2025/2026

Contents

1	Free QFT Review	5
1.1	Spin 0	6
1.2	Spin 1/2	7
1.3	Spin 1	7
2	Interacting Fields	9
2.1	S-Matrix	9
2.2	Cross Sections	10
2.3	Decay Rates	14
2.4	LSZ reduction and Green's functions	16
	Appendices	19
A	Notation and Conventions	19
B	Computations and further developments	23

Introduction

In these notes, we will explore the fascinating world of Quantum Field Theory (QFT). QFT is a fundamental framework in physics that combines classical field theory, special relativity, and quantum mechanics. It provides a powerful language for describing the behavior of particles and fields at the most fundamental level. We assume are going to assume that the reader has a basic understanding of quantum mechanics and special relativity, as well as some familiarity with classical field theory and quantum field theory of free fields (Which will anyway be reviewed in the first chapter).

There exist different motivations for studying QFT: it provides a framework for describing the interactions between particles and fields, and it has been successful in explaining a wide range of phenomena, from the behavior of subatomic particles to the properties of condensed matter systems. Additionally:

- QFT is the language of the Standard Model of particle physics, which describes the fundamental particles and their interactions (except for gravity); it is used for the quantization of systems with an **infinite number of degrees of freedom**, such as fields; it is essential for understanding the behavior of particles at high energies and small distances, where quantum effects become significant; and it provides a framework for describing the behavior of particles in curved spacetime, which is important for understanding phenomena such as black holes and the early universe.
- It is a successful framework for describing the behavior of particles and fields at the most fundamental level, incorporating both quantum mechanics and special relativity:
 - At high energies we can witness **particles creation and annihilation**, which cannot be described by non-relativistic quantum mechanics; QFT provides a framework for describing these processes, in an infinite-dimensional system, where the number of particles is not fixed.
 - QFT is a relativistic theory, which means that it is consistent with the principles of special relativity, implmenting **causality** and **Lorentz invariance**; this is essential for describing the behavior of particles at high energies and small distances, where relativistic effects become significant. So two events that are spacelike separated cannot influence each other

$$(x - y)^2 = (x^0 - y^0)^2 - \sum_{i=1}^3 (x^i - y^i)^2 < 0 \implies [\mathcal{O}(x), \mathcal{O}(y)] = 0,$$

thus the events are causally disconnected, ensuring causality.

- Particles are described as excitations of underlying fields, which can be created and annihilated; this allows for a more complete description of particle interactions and the behavior of particles at high energies. Examples of particles and underlying fields include:
 - **Scalar field:** $\phi(x) \implies$ spin-0 particles (e.g., Higgs boson).
 - **Spinor field:** $\psi(x) \implies$ spin-1/2 particles (e.g., electrons, quarks).
 - **Vector field:** $A_\mu(x) \implies$ spin-1 particles (e.g., photons, W and Z bosons).
- The **Standard Model** of particle physics is a quantum field theory that describes the fundamental particles and their interactions (except for gravity); it has been successful in explaining a wide range of phenomena, from the behavior of subatomic particles to the properties of condensed matter systems. It is a quantum field theory that describes the electromagnetic, weak, and strong interactions, through the exchange of gauge bosons among fields of spin 0, 1/2, and 1 particles.
- The inclusion of gravity in a quantum field theory framework is an open problem in theoretical physics, but can be approached by inserting the metric tensor of general relativity

$$g^{\mu\nu} = \eta^{\mu\nu} + h^{\mu\nu}.$$

While there are approaches to quantizing gravity, such as string theory and loop quantum gravity, a complete and consistent theory of quantum gravity has not yet been developed. Quanta of the gravitational field are called gravitons, which are hypothetical spin-2 particles that mediate the gravitational interaction, but they have not been observed experimentally. These notes will not cover quantum gravity, but it is an important area of research in theoretical physics which sometimes will be mentioned throughout the notes.

The main goal of these notes is to provide a comprehensive understanding of interacting quantum field theories, which are essential for describing the behavior of particles and fields at the most fundamental level, as well as mathematical methods for making theoretical predictions on interactions among particles. We will cover a wide range of topics, including:

TODO: Check and change in the end

- The quantization of free fields, which provides the foundation for understanding the behavior of particles and fields in quantum field theory.
- The construction of interacting quantum field theories, which are essential for describing the behavior of particles and fields at the most fundamental level.
- The use of perturbation theory and Feynman diagrams to calculate scattering amplitudes and other physical observables in quantum field theory.
- The renormalization of quantum field theories, which is necessary to make sense of the infinities that arise in perturbation theory and to extract meaningful physical predictions from the theory.
- The application of quantum field theory to the Standard Model of particle physics, which describes the fundamental particles and their interactions (except for gravity).

QFT is one of the most successful and powerful frameworks in physics, and it has been instrumental in our understanding of the fundamental nature of the universe. This theory has been tested and

confirmed by a wide range of experiments, some of which tested the predictions of QFT to an extraordinary degree of precision. For example, the anomalous magnetic moment of the electron has been measured to an accuracy of one part in a trillion ($\sim 10^{-13}$), and the predictions of QFT have been confirmed to this level of precision. Additionally, the discovery of the Higgs boson at the Large Hadron Collider in 2012 provided further confirmation of the predictions of QFT and the Standard Model.

Another essential aspect of these notes is to provide a comprehensive understanding of the importance of symmetries in quantum field theory, which play a crucial role in determining the behavior of particles and fields. We will explore the concept of gauge symmetries, which are local symmetries that arise in quantum field theories and are responsible for the interactions between particles and fields. We will also discuss the role of global symmetries, which are symmetries that do not depend on spacetime coordinates, and their implications for the behavior of particles and fields. In the end we will argue that *a QFT is essentially defined by its fields and its symmetries* (statement that will be made more precise in the end of the notes), and we will see how symmetries can be used to constrain the behavior of particles and fields, and to make predictions about their interactions.

For a more comprehensive introduction to quantum field theory, we recommend the following textbooks:

- **An Introduction to Quantum Field Theory** by Michael E. Peskin and Daniel V. Schroeder: This is a widely used textbook that provides a comprehensive introduction to quantum field theory, covering both the theoretical foundations and practical applications of the subject. TODO: check and change in the end
- **Quantum Field Theory** by Mark Srednicki: This textbook offers a clear and concise introduction to quantum field theory, with an emphasis on the physical intuition behind the mathematical formalism.
- **Quantum Field Theory in a Nutshell** by A. Zee: This book provides a more informal and intuitive introduction to quantum field theory, making it accessible to a wider audience while still covering essential topics.
- **The Quantum Theory of Fields** by Steven Weinberg: This three-volume series is a comprehensive and rigorous treatment of quantum field theory, written by one of the pioneers in the field. It is suitable for advanced students and researchers who want a deep understanding of the subject.

For more information about the notation and conventions used in these notes, please refer to the appendix, where we provide a detailed explanation of the symbols and mathematical conventions that we will use throughout the notes (Appendix A).

Prerequisites: *Familiarity with the Lagrangian and Hamiltonian formalisms of Classical Mechanics, standard Quantum Mechanics, Special Relativity and the basics of Quantum Field Theory (free fields) is required.*

1 | Free QFT Review

A free quantum field theory does not account for interactions between particles. It describes particles that do not interact with each other, and the fields that represent them evolve independently. Free QFTs are often used as a starting point for understanding more complex interacting theories, as they provide a simpler framework to study the properties of quantum fields and particles.

The lagrangian for a free quantum field theory typically consists of kinetic terms and mass terms for the fields, without any interaction terms: it can only contain **quadratic terms** in the fields, without any higher-order interactions. Quanta of the free fields correspond to particles that do not interact with each other, and their dynamics are governed by the **free propagators** of the theory, which describe how particles propagate through spacetime without any interactions: propagators are the Green's functions of the free theory, and they determine how particles propagate from one point to another in spacetime with determined probability amplitudes.

We will review the free quantum field theories for different types of particles, including scalar fields (spin 0), fermionic fields (spin 1/2), and gauge fields (spin 1). We will also discuss the symmetries of these theories and how they lead to conservation laws through Noether's theorem. This review will provide a foundation for understanding more complex interacting quantum field theories, and it will also highlight the differences between free and interacting theories, as well as the role of symmetries in quantum field theory.

1.1 | Spin 0

For a real scalar field $\phi(x)$, the free Lagrangian is given by

$$\mathcal{L} = \frac{1}{2}(\partial_\mu \phi)^2 - \frac{1}{2}m^2 \phi^2, \quad (1.1.1)$$

where m is the mass of the scalar particle. The equation of motion derived from this Lagrangian is the **Klein-Gordon equation**:

$$(\square + m^2)\phi = 0, \quad (1.1.2)$$

where $\square = \partial_\mu \partial^\mu$ is the d'Alembertian operator. The solutions to this equation describe free scalar particles with mass m . This is a classical equation of motion, having the same role of Maxwell's equations in classical electromagnetism, but for a scalar field $\phi(x)$ instead of a vector field $A^\mu(x)$.

The idea of quantum field theory is to promote the classical field $\phi(x)$ to a quantum operator $\hat{\phi}(x)$ that acts on a Hilbert space of states. The quantization procedure involves imposing commutation relations on the field operators, which leads to the creation and annihilation of particles. The free scalar field can be expanded in terms of creation and annihilation operators, which allows us to describe the particle content of the theory. Indeed, we can see how decomposing the field into its Fourier modes leads to the interpretation of the quanta of the field as particles with specific momenta and energies:

$$\phi(x) = \int \frac{d^3\mathbf{k}}{(2\pi)^3} e^{i\mathbf{k}\cdot\mathbf{x}} \tilde{\phi}(t, \mathbf{k}),$$

where each mode can be computed by using this ansatz in the Klein-Gordon equation in momentum space, leading to the dispersion relation of an harmonic oscillator represented by on-shell particles with energy $E_{\mathbf{k}} = \omega_{\mathbf{k}} = \sqrt{\mathbf{k}^2 + m^2}$:

$$(\partial_t^2 + \omega_{\mathbf{k}}^2) \tilde{\phi}(t, \mathbf{k}) = 0,$$

showing how the free scalar field can be interpreted as a collection of independent harmonic oscillators, each corresponding to a different momentum mode.

In order to quantize the free scalar field, we have to promote the fields themselves to operators and impose the canonical commutation relations, which leads to the creation and annihilation of particles. Before showing how to do that, it is crucial to note that $\hat{\phi}(x)$ depends on both space and time, enforcing the Heisenberg picture of quantum mechanics, where operators evolve in time while states remain fixed. The canonical commutation relations for the scalar field are given by

$$[\hat{\phi}(t, \mathbf{x}), \hat{\pi}(t, \mathbf{y})] = i\delta^3(\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}),$$

where $\hat{\pi}(x) = \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial(\partial_0 \phi(x))} = \partial_0 \hat{\phi}(x)$ is the conjugate momentum operator. This constraint along with reality of the field $\hat{\phi}(x) = \hat{\phi}^\dagger(x)$ allows us to express the field operator in terms of **creation and annihilation operators**:

$$\hat{\phi}(x) = \int \frac{d^3\mathbf{k}}{(2\pi)^3} \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\omega_{\mathbf{k}}}} \left(\hat{a}_{\mathbf{k}} e^{-ik \cdot x} + \hat{a}_{\mathbf{k}}^\dagger e^{ik \cdot x} \right),$$

where $k \cdot x = \omega_{\mathbf{k}} t - \mathbf{k} \cdot \mathbf{x} = k^\mu x_\mu$, and $\omega_{\mathbf{k}} = k^0$. The creation and annihilation (ladder) operators satisfy the following commutation relations

$$\begin{cases} [\hat{a}_{\mathbf{k}}, \hat{a}_{\mathbf{k}'}^\dagger] = (2\pi)^3 \delta^3(\mathbf{k} - \mathbf{k}'), \\ [\hat{a}_{\mathbf{k}}, \hat{a}_{\mathbf{k}'}] = [\hat{a}_{\mathbf{k}}^\dagger, \hat{a}_{\mathbf{k}'}^\dagger] = 0. \end{cases}$$

Note that while the field operator $\hat{\phi}(x)$ is Hermitian and time dependent, the creation and annihilation operators are not, and they are responsible for creating and destroying particles in the quantum field theory. The **vacuum state** $|0\rangle$ is defined as the state that is annihilated by all annihilation operators:

$$\hat{a}_{\mathbf{k}} |0\rangle = 0 \quad \forall \mathbf{k},$$

while we can create one-particle states by acting with the creation operators on the vacuum, which adds one quanta of the field with momentum $\mathbf{k}$:

$$|\mathbf{k}\rangle = \sqrt{2\omega_{\mathbf{k}}} \hat{a}_{\mathbf{k}}^{\dagger} |0\rangle,$$

and more generally, we can create multi-particle states by acting with multiple creation operators on the vacuum, which leads to the **Fock space** of the theory. With this definition of single particle states, we can compute the inner product between two single particle states, which is given by

$$\langle \mathbf{k} | \mathbf{k}' \rangle = 2\omega_{\mathbf{k}} \delta^3(\mathbf{k} - \mathbf{k}'),$$

showing that the single particle states are orthogonal and normalized with respect to the relativistic normalization convention. The normalization $\sqrt{2\omega_{\mathbf{k}}}$ is arbitrary, but important for ensuring that the probabilities computed in the theory are consistent with relativistic invariance.

Remark. *To find a Lorentz invariant measure, we can start from the Minkowski space measure d^4k and impose the on-shell condition $k^2 = m^2$ using a delta function along with a step function to ensure that we only consider positive energy solutions:*

$$\int d^4k \delta(k^2 - m^2) \theta(k^0) = \int \frac{d^3\mathbf{k}}{2\omega_{\mathbf{k}}}.$$

We have then found the Lorentz invariant measure $\frac{d^3\mathbf{k}}{2\omega_{\mathbf{k}}}$ for integrating over the momentum space of on-shell particles, which is crucial for ensuring that the theory is consistent with special relativity. The previous normalization of the single particle states is consistent with this Lorentz invariant measure, since it ensures that the inner product between single particle states is Lorentz invariant, and it also allows us to compute probabilities and cross sections in a way that is consistent with relativistic invariance:

$$\int \frac{d^3\mathbf{k}}{(2\pi)^3} \frac{1}{2\omega_{\mathbf{k}}} |\mathbf{k}\rangle \langle \mathbf{k}| = 1,$$

which is the completeness relation for the single particle states in the theory. This ensures that we can express any state in the Fock space as a superposition of single particle states, and it also allows us to compute transition amplitudes and probabilities in a way that is consistent with relativistic invariance.

1.1.1 | Feynman's Propagator

1.1.2 | Noether's Theorem

1.2 | Spin 1/2

1.3 | Spin 1

2 | Interacting Fields

2.0.1 | Dimensional Analysis

2.1 | S-Matrix

[...]

We typically use Heisenberg picture, so if we want to compute the amplitude of a determined process, we can write it as

$$\langle f | \hat{S} | i \rangle = \langle f, \infty | i, -\infty \rangle,$$

where $|i\rangle$ and $|f\rangle$ are the initial and final states of the system (time independent), respectively. The S-matrix element $\langle f | \hat{S} | i \rangle$ gives us the amplitude for the transition from the initial state $|i\rangle$ to the final state $|f\rangle$ due to the interaction described by the S-matrix.

2.2 | Cross Sections

If we analyze a scattering process, such as the Rutherford scattering, we can see how a beam of particles is scattered by a target. We consider the nucleus as a still sphere, while the alpha particles are much smaller. The geometric cross section of the target is given by

$$\sigma \equiv \pi R^2,$$

where R is the radius of the target. One can compute the number of particles that are scattered by the target, which is given by

$$N = n_B \cdot \sigma, \quad n_B = \frac{N_B}{A},$$

where n_B is the number density of the beam, N_B is the number of particles in the beam, and A is the area of the target. The cross section σ can be interpreted as an effective area that quantifies the likelihood of a scattering event occurring when a particle from the beam interacts with the target.

Now we want to take this model and generalize it to quantum field theory, where we can compute the probability of scattering processes; we want to extend the model

- for any type of scattering process, or interaction;
- for a probability of scattering, not just a number of particles.

If we assume a beam of particles along the z -axis, we can define the **impact parameter** $\mathbf{b}$, which represents the perpendicular distance from the trajectory of the incoming particle to the center of the target: the coordinates perpendicular to the plane of scattering:

$$N = \int d^2\mathbf{b} n_B P(\mathbf{b}) = n_B \int d^2\mathbf{b} P(\mathbf{b}),$$

thus we can now define the **cross section** as

$$\sigma = \int d^2\mathbf{b} P(\mathbf{b}),$$

and its differential form as

$$\frac{d\sigma}{d\Omega} = \int d^2\mathbf{b} \frac{P(\mathbf{b})}{d\Omega},$$

or in the measure of the space of final states as

$$\frac{d\sigma}{df} = \int d^2\mathbf{b} \frac{P(\mathbf{b})}{df}.$$

It makes sense to use eigenstates of the momentum operator as the initial and final states of the scattering process, since they are the natural basis for describing particles in quantum field theory (errors on $p \dots$)

$$\Delta p \Delta x \geq \frac{\hbar}{2}, \quad \Delta p = 0 \implies \Delta x \rightarrow \infty,$$

We also know that the probability of scattering is given by the square of the amplitude $\langle f | \hat{S} | i \rangle \sim \delta^{(4)}(p_i - p_f)$, but then

$$P \sim |\langle f | \hat{S} | i \rangle|^2 \sim |\delta^{(4)}(p_i - p_f)|^2 = \delta^{(4)}(p_i - p_f) \delta^{(4)}(0) \dots$$

TODO: Add drawing

one way to overcome this problem is to consider a finite volume V and a finite time T , so that the delta function can be regularized and then take only at the end the limit $V \rightarrow \infty$ and $T \rightarrow \infty$. This is a common technique in quantum field theory to handle divergences and make sense of scattering amplitudes. By working in a finite volume and time, we can ensure that the calculations are well-defined and then take the appropriate limits to recover physical results.

We will instead follow the Peskin and Schroeder approach, which is to consider the states as wave packets in the momentum space, which are localized in both position and momentum space, thus avoiding the issues with the delta function. This approach allows us to compute scattering amplitudes and cross sections without encountering the divergences associated with plane wave states. By using wave packets, we can ensure that the initial and final states are well-defined and that the scattering probabilities are finite and physically meaningful.

We can consider an initial state as a two particle state with momenta p_a and p_b , and a final state as a N particle state: [...] For incoming states we replace $|p_i\rangle$ with $|\phi_i\rangle$, which is a wave packet centered around the momentum p_i : TODO: Drawing

$$|p_i\rangle \rightarrow |\phi_i\rangle = \int d^3\mathbf{k} (2\pi)^3 \frac{1}{\sqrt{2E_{\mathbf{k}}}} \phi_i(\mathbf{k}) |\mathbf{k}\rangle,$$

with

$$\langle \phi_i | \phi_i \rangle = \int \frac{d^3\mathbf{k}}{(2\pi)^3} |\phi_i(\mathbf{k})|^2 = 1,$$

remembering that $\langle \mathbf{k} | \mathbf{k}' \rangle = 2E_{\mathbf{k}} (2\pi)^3 \delta^{(3)}(\mathbf{k} - \mathbf{k}')$; all of this indicates that $\phi_i(\mathbf{k})$ is a very narrow normalized function centered around p_i . TODO: Add graph of the wave packet

Example (LHC collider). We can assume, very conservatively, that the LHC collider has $\Delta p \sim 1$ MeV, such that ...

Example (Gaussian wave packet). We can consider a Gaussian wave packet centered around p_i with a width σ :

$$\phi(\mathbf{k}) = \dots$$

This wave packet is normalized and has a well-defined momentum distribution, allowing us to compute scattering amplitudes and cross sections without encountering divergences. [...]

$$\begin{aligned} |p_a\rangle &\sim |\phi_a\rangle = \\ |p_b\rangle &\sim |\phi_b\rangle = \dots \end{aligned}$$

where we exploited the dependence of $\phi_b(\mathbf{k})$ upon $\mathbf{b}$ the impact parameter

...

For the outgoing states we can consider just the momentum eigenstates, since the scattering has already happened, thus we can write

$$|\phi_i\rangle = |p_i\rangle, \quad \forall i = 1, \dots, N.$$

[...]

We can consider the S-matrix element for the transition by rewriting it as

$$\hat{S} = \mathbb{I} + i\hat{T},$$

where the identity term corresponds to the case where no scattering occurs, while the $i\hat{T}$ term corresponds to the case some interactions among the fields, i.e. scattering, occur. Thus we can write

$$\langle p_1, \dots, p_N | i\hat{T} | \phi_a, \phi_b \rangle = (2\pi)^4 \delta^{(4)} \left(p_a + p_b - \sum_{i=1}^N p_i \right) i\mathcal{M}(p_1, \dots, p_N),$$

where the delta function ensures the conservation of energy and momentum, and $\mathcal{M}(p_1, \dots, p_N)$ is the **invariant matrix element** or **scattering amplitude** for the process, which encodes the dynamics of the interaction. The invariant amplitude can be computed using Feynman diagrams and the rules of quantum field theory, and it is a key quantity in determining the cross section for the scattering process.

Thus we can now compute the differential cross section as $\frac{d\sigma}{df} = \int d^2 \frac{dP}{df}$, where the probability of scattering is given by

$$\frac{dP}{df} = |\langle p_1, \dots, p_N, +\infty | i\hat{T} | \phi_a, \phi_b, -\infty \rangle|^2,$$

and the measure of the space of final states is normalized as¹

$$df = \prod_{i=1}^N \frac{d^3 \mathbf{p}_i}{(2\pi)^3} \frac{1}{2E_{p_i}}.$$

Now we can put everything back together and write the final expression for the differential cross section after conti

$$\Phi = 2E_a 2E_b |v_a - v_b| = 4|E_b p_a^z - E_a p_b^z|.$$

Φ is invariant under boosts along the beam axis, and rotations around the beam axis, thus it can only depend on the Lorentz invariants of the process, and thus it transforms as the inverse of an area in the plane perpendicular to the beam axis, thus ...

We can also perform a change of reference frame in order to reverse the problem: we can consider the target as the beam and the beam as the target, it all depends on the symmetry of the problem, and the choice of the reference frame. This is a common technique in scattering theory, where we can choose a reference frame that simplifies the calculations (even center of mass, it depends) and makes it easier to analyze the scattering process. By considering different reference frames, we can gain insights into the dynamics of the interaction and compute cross sections more efficiently.

Example ($2 \rightarrow 2$ scattering in center of mass frame). We can consider a simple scattering process where two particles collide and produce two particles in the final state. In the center of mass frame, the initial momenta of the particles are equal and opposite, and we can analyze the scattering process using the invariant amplitude $\mathcal{M}$ and the phase space factor Φ to compute the differential cross section for this process.

The incoming particles have momenta p_1 and p_2 , and the outgoing particles have momenta p_3 and p_4 , and their spatial parts is conserved: $\mathbf{p}_1 + \mathbf{p}_2 = \mathbf{p}_3 + \mathbf{p}_4 = 0$ (since we are in the center of mass frame). The energy of the particles is given by the energy momentum relation $E_i = \sqrt{\mathbf{p}_i^2 + m_i^2}$, where m_i is the mass of the particle. We can write

$$d\Pi_2 = \frac{d^3 \mathbf{p}_3}{(2\pi)^3 2E_3} \frac{d^3 \mathbf{p}_4}{(2\pi)^3 2E_4} \delta^{(4)}(p_1 + p_2 - p_3 - p_4),$$

¹We can convince ourself with the resolution of the identity for 1 particle states as ...

which, after integrating in $d^3\mathbf{p}_4$ using the delta function, gives $\mathbf{p}_4 = -\mathbf{p}_3$, and thus using then polar coordinates for $d^3\mathbf{p}_3 = p^2 dp d\Omega$, we can write

$$E_3 = \sqrt{p^2 + m_3^2}, \quad E_4 = \sqrt{p^2 + m_4^2},$$

and thus

$$\int dp \delta(E_1 + E_2 - E_3 - E_4) = \frac{1}{\left| \frac{p}{E_3} + \frac{p}{E_4} \right|} = \frac{E_3 E_4}{p(E_3 + E_4)} = \frac{E_3 E_4}{pE},$$

where the last energy E is the total energy of the system in the center of mass frame, which is given by $E = E_1 + E_2 = E_3 + E_4$. Thus we can write

$$d\Pi_2 = d\Omega \frac{p}{16\pi^2 E},$$

with a flux $\Phi = 2E_a 2E_b |v_a - v_b|$, with now

$$|v_a - v_b| = \left| \frac{|\mathbf{p}_1|}{E_1} + \frac{|\mathbf{p}_2|}{E_2} \right| = p_{in} \frac{E}{E_1 E_2},$$

where p_{in} is the magnitude of the incoming momenta (which are equal in the center of mass frame) $p_{in} = |\mathbf{p}_1| = |\mathbf{p}_2|$. Thus we can write the final expression for the differential cross section as

$$\frac{d\sigma}{d\Omega} = \frac{1}{64\pi^2 E^2} \frac{p}{p_{in}} |\mathcal{M}|^2,$$

where we used the fact that $E_1 E_2 = \frac{E^2}{4}$ in the center of mass frame. This expression allows us to compute the differential cross section for the $2 \rightarrow 2$ scattering process in the center of mass frame, given the invariant amplitude $\mathcal{M}$ and the kinematic variables of the process.

Remark. *Most of the time this problem is independent of the azimuthal angle ϕ , thus we can integrate over it and write $d\Omega = 2\pi d\cos\theta$, thus simplifying the expression for the differential cross section.*

2.3 | Decay Rates

We can similarly deal with **unstable particles**, which are particles that can decay into other particles. The decay rate of an unstable particle is given by the probability per unit time that the particle will decay, and it can be computed using the S-matrix formalism in a similar way to how we compute scattering amplitudes and cross sections for stable particles. By analyzing the transition amplitudes for the decay process, we can determine the decay rate and the branching ratios for different decay channels, which provide insights into the properties of the unstable particle and its interactions with other particles.

The decay rate Γ of an unstable particle can be computed as

$$\Gamma = \frac{\text{Number of decays per unit time}}{\text{Number of particles}},$$

and we can define the lifetime τ of the particle as the inverse of the decay rate:

$$\tau = \frac{1}{\Gamma}.$$

The decay rate can be computed using the S-matrix element for the transition from the initial state (the unstable particle) to the final state (the decay products), and it is related to the invariant amplitude $\mathcal{M}$ for the decay process. We cannot directly apply the limit for $t_i \rightarrow -\infty$, since the particle is unstable and thus it cannot exist for an infinite amount of time, thus we need to consider a finite time interval for the decay process, but we can make a simplification: if we assume the particle to have a lifetime way longer than the time scale of the interaction, we can still apply the S-matrix formalism and compute the decay rate using the invariant amplitude for the decay process, while treating the unstable particle as if it were stable during the interaction.

Defining the differential decay rate as

$$\frac{d\Gamma}{df} = \frac{1}{T} dP,$$

where T is the time interval during which the decay process occurs $T = t_f - t_i$, and dP is the probability of the decay process occurring within that time interval, we can compute the total decay rate by integrating over the phase space of the final states; let us first write the expression for δ function in the limit of finite and large T :

$$\delta(0) = \int_{t_i}^{t_f} dt e^{i(E_i - E_f)t} \Big|_{t_f \rightarrow \infty, t_i \rightarrow -\infty},$$

After surpassing the subtleties of defining the asymptotic states for unstable particles, we can write the expression for the decay rate after integrating over the phase space of the final states as

$$d\Gamma = \frac{1}{2m} |\mathcal{M}|^2 d\Pi_N,$$

where m is the mass of the unstable particle, $\mathcal{M}$ is the invariant amplitude for the decay process, and $d\Pi_N$ is the phase space factor for the N-particle final state, which accounts for the kinematics of the decay products and ensures that energy and momentum are conserved in the decay process. This expression allows us to compute the decay rate for an unstable particle given the invariant amplitude and the kinematic variables of the decay process.

Identical particles. When dealing with identical particles among the decay products, we need to take into account the symmetrization (for bosons) or antisymmetrization (for fermions) of the wave

TODO: Add drawing.

function. This means that the scattering amplitude must be modified to include the appropriate symmetry factors, which can affect the calculation of cross sections and decay rates in order to consider the spin statistics theorem

$$|p_3, p_4\rangle = \pm |p_4, p_3\rangle.$$

This can be accomplished in two ways: one can restrict the integration over the phase space to a specific region that accounts for the indistinguishability of the particles (thus over all final inequivalent states), or one can include a symmetry factor in the calculation of the amplitude (such as the permutation number $\frac{1}{N!}$) to account for the number of identical particles in the final state. Both approaches ensure that the physical predictions are consistent with the principles of quantum mechanics and the statistics of identical particles.

2.4 | LSZ reduction and Green's functions

In this section we aim to show how the S-matrix elements can be computed from the Green's functions of the interacting theory. This is done by the LSZ reduction formula, which relates the S-matrix elements to the time-ordered correlation functions of the fields.

$$\langle f | \hat{S} | i \rangle \rightarrow \langle \Omega | T \{ \hat{\phi}(x_1) \hat{\phi}(x_2) \cdots \hat{\phi}(x_n) \} | \Omega \rangle$$

where

$$\begin{cases} \hat{\phi} \text{ is the field operator of the interacting theory,} \\ | \Omega \rangle \text{ is the vacuum state of the interacting theory.} \end{cases}$$

We now have to analyze the structure of the two point function of the interacting theory, investigating its physical content and how it relates to the S-matrix elements, and finally relate it to the LSZ reduction formula for connecting the scattering matrix elements to the n-point Green's functions. We will start from a **real scalar theory** before generalizing to more complicated theories.

2.4.1 | Two Point Functions

To analyze the structure of the two point function, we start from the definition of the time-ordered two point function in the interacting theory:

$$\langle \Omega | T \{ \hat{\phi}(x) \hat{\phi}(y) \} | \Omega \rangle ,$$

we can now insert a complete set of states between the two field operators:

$$\mathbb{I} = \langle \Omega | \Omega \rangle + \sum_{\lambda \notin | \Omega \rangle} | \lambda \rangle \langle \lambda | ,$$

where $| \lambda \rangle$ are the eigenstates of [...] and $| \Omega \rangle$ is the vacuum state of the interacting theory.²

[...]

If we now assume $x^0 > y^0$, the time-ordering operator T does not change the order of the fields, and we can write:

$$\langle \Omega | \hat{\phi}(x) \hat{\phi}(y) | \Omega \rangle = \langle \Omega | \hat{\phi}(x) \left(| \Omega \rangle \langle \Omega | + \sum_{\lambda \notin | \Omega \rangle} \int \frac{d^3 \mathbf{p}}{(2\pi)^3} \frac{1}{2E_{\mathbf{p}}(\lambda)} | \lambda_{\mathbf{p}} \rangle \langle \lambda_{\mathbf{p}} | \right) \hat{\phi}(y) | \Omega \rangle ,$$

and if we now relate $\hat{\phi}(x)$ to $\hat{\phi}(0)$ by a translation

$$\hat{U}_{\mathbf{p}} = e^{i\hat{P} \cdot x} \implies \hat{\phi}(x) = e^{i\hat{P} \cdot x} \hat{\phi}(0) e^{-i\hat{P} \cdot x} = \hat{U}_{\mathbf{p}} \hat{\phi}(0) \hat{U}_{\mathbf{p}}^\dagger ,$$

we can compute the terms by assuming that the vacuum is translationally invariant, and that the states $| \lambda_{\mathbf{p}} \rangle$ are eigenstates of the momentum operator $\hat{P}$ with eigenvalue p :

$$\langle \Omega | \hat{\phi}(x) | \lambda_{\mathbf{p}} \rangle = \langle \Omega | \hat{\phi}(0) | \lambda_{\mathbf{p}} \rangle e^{-ip \cdot x} ,$$

from vacuum invariance and momentum eigenstate properties. We can now assume a Lorentz transformation Λ to exist such that $\Lambda p = (m\lambda, \mathbf{0})$, and the corresponding unitary operator $\hat{U}(\Lambda)$ to exist such that

$$\langle \Omega | \hat{\phi}(0) | \lambda_{\mathbf{p}} \rangle = \langle \Omega | \hat{U}(\Lambda)^\dagger \hat{U}(\Lambda) \hat{\phi}(0) \hat{U}(\Lambda)^\dagger \hat{U}(\Lambda) | \lambda_{\mathbf{p}} \rangle = \langle \Omega | \hat{\phi}(0) | \lambda_{\mathbf{0}} \rangle ,$$

²The vacuum state has to be different from the free theory one, since ...

since the vacuum is invariant under Lorentz transformations, and the field operator transforms trivially since $\hat{\phi}(\Lambda 0) = \hat{\phi}(0)$. Hence

$$\langle \Omega | \hat{\phi}(x) | \lambda_{\mathbf{p}} \rangle = \langle \Omega | \hat{\phi}(0) | \lambda_{\mathbf{0}} \rangle e^{-ip \cdot x} = e^{-ip \cdot x} F(\lambda).$$

Appendices

A | Notation and Conventions

Conventions on Units and Natural Units

We are going to use natural units throughout these notes, where the speed of light c and the reduced Planck constant $\hbar$ are set to 1:

$$c = 1, \quad \hbar = 1.$$

In natural units, all physical quantities are expressed in terms of a single unit of energy (or mass) and measured in Electronvolts (eV) and multiples thereof, since the dimensions of length and time are related to energy through the relations $E = mc^2$ and $E = \hbar\omega$. This simplifies many equations in quantum field theory and allows us to focus on the essential physics without being distracted by factors of c and $\hbar$. In these units, we have:

$$\begin{aligned} [E] &= [M] = [L]^{-1} = [T]^{-1}, \\ [\hbar] &= 1, \\ [c] &= 1. \end{aligned}$$

We report some useful conversion factors between natural units and SI units:

$$\begin{aligned} 1 \text{ GeV} &\approx 1.602 \times 10^{-10} \text{ J}, \\ 1 \text{ GeV} &\approx 1.783 \times 10^{-27} \text{ kg}, \\ 1 \text{ GeV}^{-1} &\approx 0.1975 \text{ fm}, \\ 1 \text{ GeV}^{-1} &\approx 6.582 \times 10^{-25} \text{ s}, \end{aligned}$$

and also

$$\begin{aligned} \hbar c &\approx 197.3 \text{ MeV} \cdot \text{fm}, \\ 1 \text{ fm} &\approx 10^{-15} \text{ m}, \end{aligned}$$

where the femtometer (fm) is a common unit of length in nuclear and particle physics, often called a Fermi: it is approximately the length of a proton or neutron radius:

$$r_p \sim 0.8 \text{ fm} = \frac{0.8}{197.3} \text{ MeV}^{-1}.$$

Conventions on Electromagnetism

In order to avoid confusion, we will use the **Heaviside-Lorentz** units for electromagnetism throughout these notes: in these units, the electric charge e is dimensionless and appears ex-

plicitly in the interaction terms of the Lagrangian, making it easier to identify the strength of electromagnetic interaction, while Maxwell equations take a more symmetric form.

Explicitly, in Heaviside-Lorentz units, we have the following relations:

- $\epsilon_0 = \mu_0 = 1$, where ϵ_0 is the *vacuum permittivity* and μ_0 is the *vacuum permeability*: this means that the electric and magnetic fields have the same units and that the speed of light c is equal to 1 (these units are consistent with the natural units we are using).
- The **electric charge** e is dimensionless and connected to the fine-structure constant α by

$$\alpha = \frac{e^2}{4\pi\epsilon_0\hbar c} = \frac{e^2}{4\pi} \approx \frac{1}{137}.$$

- The **electric potential** Φ is defined as

$$\Phi = \frac{Q}{4\pi R},$$

where Q is the charge and R is the distance from the charge: this means that the electric potential has the same units as the electric field E (which is consistent with the fact that in Heaviside-Lorentz units, $\epsilon_0 = 1$).

- The **Maxwell equations** take the following form:

$$\begin{aligned}\nabla \cdot \mathbf{E} &= \rho, \\ \nabla \cdot \mathbf{B} &= 0, \\ \nabla \times \mathbf{E} &= -\frac{\partial \mathbf{B}}{\partial t}, \\ \nabla \times \mathbf{B} &= \mathbf{J} + \frac{\partial \mathbf{E}}{\partial t},\end{aligned}$$

where $\mathbf{E}$ is the electric field, $\mathbf{B}$ is the magnetic field, ρ is the charge density, and $\mathbf{J}$ is the current density: this symmetric form of Maxwell equations is one of the reasons why Heaviside-Lorentz units are often preferred in theoretical physics, especially in quantum field theory. Basically the Heaviside-Lorentz units are a rationalized version of the Gaussian units, where the factors of 4π are absorbed into the definitions of the fields and charges, leading to simpler equations and making it easier to identify the physical constants that govern the interactions.

Conventions on the Metric and Spacetime

We will use the **mostly minus** convention for the metric tensor $g_{\mu\nu}$ in Minkowski spacetime, which is defined as

$$g_{\mu\nu} = g^{\mu\nu} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

This means that the time component of the metric is positive, while the spatial components are negative; using Einstein summation convention, we have the following relations among the components of the metric and v^μ , w^μ four vectors:

$$\begin{aligned}v \cdot w &= g_{\mu\nu} v^\mu w^\nu = v^0 w^0 - \mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{w}, \\ v^2 &= v \cdot v = g_{\mu\nu} v^\mu v^\nu = (v^0)^2 - \mathbf{v}^2, \\ v_\mu &= g_{\mu\nu} v^\nu \implies v_0 = v^0, \quad \mathbf{v} = v^i = -v_i.\end{aligned}$$

We will use greek letters μ, ν, ρ, σ to denote spacetime indices that run from 0 to 3, while Latin letters i, j, k will be used to denote spatial indices that run from 1 to 3:

$$\begin{aligned}\mu, \nu, \rho, \sigma &\in \{0, 1, 2, 3\} = \{t, x, y, z\}, \\ i, j, k &\in \{1, 2, 3\} = \{x, y, z\}.\end{aligned}$$

Fourier Transforms

We will use the following conventions for Fourier transforms of a function $f(x)$ in four-dimensional spacetime:

$$\begin{aligned}f(x) &= \int \frac{d^4p}{(2\pi)^4} e^{-ip \cdot x} \tilde{f}(p), \\ \tilde{f}(p) &= \int d^4x e^{ip \cdot x} f(x).\end{aligned}$$

We highlight that the Fourier transform of a function $f(x)$ is denoted by $\tilde{f}(p)$, and that the integration measure includes a factor of $(2\pi)^{-4}$ in the inverse Fourier transform, which is a common convention in quantum field theory: in the space of coordinates, we have the measure d^4x , while in the momentum space, we have the measure $\frac{d^4p}{(2\pi)^4}$. This convention ensures that the Fourier transform and its inverse are consistent and that the normalization of the fields and operators in quantum field theory is correct.

Feynman Diagrams

In these notes, we will use Feynman diagrams as a graphical representation of the interactions between particles and fields in quantum field theory. We will use the following conventions for Feynman diagrams:

TODO: Check and change in the end

- Time will be represented on the horizontal axis, going from left to right, which is a common convention in quantum field theory; this means that the left side of the diagram will represent the initial state of the particles, while the right side will represent the final state after the interaction has occurred.
- Solid lines will represent fermions (spin-1/2 particles), while dashed lines will represent bosons (spin-0 or spin-1 particles).
- Arrows on the lines will indicate the direction of particle flow, with arrows pointing towards the interaction vertex for incoming particles and away from the vertex for outgoing particles.
- Wavy lines will represent gauge bosons (spin-1 particles that mediate interactions), such as photons, W and Z bosons, and gluons.
- The vertices in the diagrams will represent interaction points where particles interact according to the rules of the theory, with each vertex corresponding to a specific term in the Lagrangian of the quantum field theory.

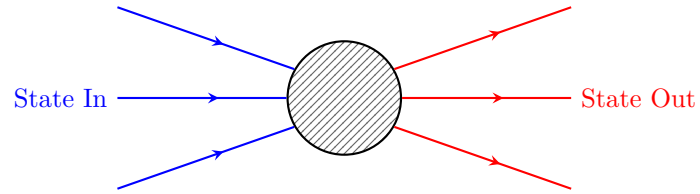


Figure 1: Generic Feynman diagram representing an interaction between particles, where the blue lines represent incoming particles (initial state) and the red lines represent outgoing particles (final state). The black box represents the interaction vertex, which corresponds to a specific term in the Lagrangian of the quantum field theory.

B | Computations and further developments